

Laughing in the Colonizer's Language:

Humor and Orientalism in *Beer in the Snooker Club*

In his semi-autobiographical novel,¹ *Beer in the Snooker Club*, Egyptian author Waguih Ghali situates the main character Ram within the linguistic and cultural tensions shaped by colonial education. Set in the 1950s and early 1960s, Ram lives in Cairo—in an Egypt that is formally independent from the British, yet still very much structured by British colonial influence. The text follows Ram during an important period of modern Egyptian history: the final years of British occupation, the 1952 Revolution, and the 1956 nationalization of the Suez Canal and subsequent Suez Crisis. The remnants and legacies of colonial rule were especially felt in the British schools which Ram and his best friend Font attend,² shaping the frameworks in which they understand themselves, their language, and their relationship to Egyptian national identity. *Beer in the Snooker Club* chronicles Ram throughout his education in elite British schools, his exposure to communist ideals, and his interactions with a society that is marked by wealth disparities, repressive politics, and cosmopolitan culture. He experiences alienation and has a very cynical view of the world, which he expresses through humor and satire. This humor, which he sees as integral to Egyptian cultural identity, gives Ram a voice to a subjectivity that allows him to critique colonial and postcolonial Egypt.

¹ Ahdaf Soueif, "Goat Face," in *Mezzaterra: Fragments from the Common Ground* (London: Bloomsbury, 2004), 195.

² Waguih Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club* (Cairo: American University in Cairo Press, 2004).

Through his wit, Ram asserts agency and reclaims authority over the colonial terms by which he is defined. Understanding this dynamic through the frameworks of Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's *Decolonising the Mind* and Edward Said's *Orientalism*, we can see how Ghali uses humor and satire to transform the language of the colonizer and the dynamics of Orientalism into a site of resistance. *Beer in the Snooker Club* is written in English, which contests Ngũgĩ's argument that writers from the colonized world should abandon the colonizer's language.³ Yet Ghali's use of humor allows Ram—and, by extension, Ghali himself—to navigate and critique the very social, political, and cultural pressures of colonial and postcolonial Egypt. In this context, Said's theory of Orientalism, which he explains in his seminal 1979 work, describes how Western representations of the East create and maintain hierarchical structures of power.⁴ Ram's satire, often directed at symbols of British authority and the colonial schools which produced him, upends the Orientalist gaze by flipping such hierarchical structures. Ghali presents a subject who speaks back to the British systems which seek to define him—though through English rather than his native Arabic. This essay challenges Ngũgĩ's position by showing that writing in the colonizer's language does not inherently reproduce colonial dominance; instead, Ram's humor in *Beer in the Snooker Club* can be understood as a tool of critique, but also one that can reproduce the systems of power which Said defines in *Orientalism*. Rooted in what he describes as an Egyptian national identity, Ram's wit reclaims agency in English and simultaneously destabilizes and

³ Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, *Decolonising the Mind: The Politics of Language in African Literature* (London: James Currey, 1986).

⁴ Edward W. Said, *Orientalism* (New York: Vintage Books, 1979).

reproduces Orientalist stereotypes. In this essay, I will explore how colonial education—experienced by Ghali, Ngũgĩ, and Said—has shaped the understanding of language, culture, and identity in *Beer in the Snooker Club*.

Like Ngũgĩ and Said, Ghali and his semi-personal character Ram are between East and West. Both Ghali and Ram used English and French far more in their everyday lives rather than Arabic,⁵ reflecting their upbringing among the elite Egyptian Cairo. The tensions of culture and language were especially exacerbated by the British colonial schools. We see this in both Ram and Font's experiences at institutions that Ghali attended in real life,⁶ such as Victoria College. Ram is officially and legally Egyptian but is estranged from most Egyptians due to British influence, instead entrenched and entangled in the in between. He recalls, "At school Font and I had been among the very few who 'swallowed.'... We had been implanted with an expectation of 'fair play' from the English."⁷ Here, we see how deeply British norms were imposed and internalized in Ram and Font. Ngũgĩ also felt these tensions as he attended British schools in Kenya: "The language of my school was no longer the language of my culture."⁸ However, though Ghali and Ngũgĩ have similar experiences with colonial education, it influences them completely differently. Ngũgĩ responds to this linguistic fragmentation by advocating for writers to use their mother tongue, just as he shifted from writing in

⁵ Susie Thomas, "Waguhi Ghali: *Beer in the Snooker Club* (1964)," *Literary London Society*, 2016, <https://www.literarylondon.org/london-fictions/ghali-beer-in-the-snooker-club-1964>

⁶ Colin Clement and Sahar Hamouda., *Victoria College: A History Revealed* (Cairo: American University in Cairo Press, 2002), 185.

⁷ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 57.

⁸ Ngũgĩ, *Decolonising the Mind*, 28.

English to his native Gikũyũ.⁹ Ghali follows a different path, and instead of rejecting English, he reworks it through Ram's humor and satire to challenge colonial power.

Yet, Ram is also aware of his "colonial alienation,"¹⁰ a term coined by Ngũgĩ. He attempts to resist it, in English, by declaring humor as a form of Egyptian culture. After Font claims they "have no culture of our own,"¹¹ Ram claps back by insisting "that jokes to Egyptians are as much culture as calypso is to West Indians, or as spirituals and jazz to American Negroes."¹² Though this humor is articulated to what Ngũgĩ describes as the language of the colonizer, Ram understands the limitations imposed by his and Font's colonial education. He admits, "we have never learnt Arabic properly."¹³ Ram's insistence that humor, in whatever language, is a marker of Egyptian culture reveals the persistence of British linguistic dominance and his efforts to reclaim cultural meaning within English. Said, who also attended Victoria College¹⁴ echoes many of these tensions in his memoir *Out of Place*. His reflections on colonial education can be understood as an extension of the "personal dimension"¹⁵ to his theory of Orientalism. Like Ram, Said also engaged with humor as a way to oppose the dominant Western culture. However, in this case, Said used Arabic rather than English to defy colonial norms imposed in his education. Said and his friends turned the prohibited Arabic into a tool of resistance by using crude humor, mocking their English teachers, and answering questions in the most

⁹ Ibid., 27.

¹⁰ Ibid., 17.

¹¹ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 18.

¹² Ibid., 19.

¹³ Ibid.

¹⁴ It is noteworthy that Said attended Victoria College in Cairo, while Ghali was educated at the Alexandria campus.

¹⁵ Said, *Orientalism*, 25.

vulgar expressions of Arabic: “*koss omak*.”¹⁶ Though Ram operates in the colonizer’s language, his humor functions in a similar way as Said’s: to assert an Arab identity within hierarchical structures that seek to suppress it.

In *Orientalism*, Said argues that Orientalism operates by shaping how colonized subjects understand themselves and their world.¹⁷ This process of colonial domination is found especially within education, culture, and language—dynamics that we see in Ram’s British schooling and internalized European values. For example, one of the places which Ram frequents is the snooker club, a famous and elite British-style social club. The British, who occupied Egypt for over 70 years, are so ingrained in Ram that he mixes Egyptian beer to imitate Draught Bass, using humor to both participate in and mock the colonial cultural ideals which he has absorbed.¹⁸ As Ngũgĩ would likely argue, Ram’s association with cafes like Groppi’s reflect the effects of colonial education. Here, the European cultural spaces are normalized and Egyptian colonial subjects are produced through the very systems Said identifies as “a Western style for dominating, restructuring, and having authority over the Orient.”¹⁹ Though Ram is clearly influenced by British standards, he is not just the passive object of Orientalist production as Said describes.²⁰ He repeatedly mocks the world of the snooker club while simultaneously engaging with British culture. For example, he sarcastically remarks, “I’ve finished two pints of this Bass which makes me comfortable and allows my Oriental brain to wonder over

¹⁶ Edward W. Said, *Out of Place: A Memoir* (New York: Knopf, 1999), 184.

¹⁷ Said, *Orientalism*, 35.

¹⁸ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 17.

¹⁹ Said, *Orientalism*, 3.

²⁰ *Ibid.*, 97.

non-Oriental things, such as Font, and other Font's I've known, and even the Font I am sometimes."²¹ Ram uses humor and self-awareness to criticize the absurdity of internalized Orientalist norms as he navigates the spaces that such norms have created. In doing so, he asserts his intellectual autonomy in the very language of the British, much to Ngũgĩ's opposing view that writing in one's indigenous language is "part and parcel of the anti-imperialist struggles."²² Even within the imposed norms of speaking English, Ram can still find space for self-expression and agency through his satire.

During the Egyptian Revolution, Ram, Font, and Edna, Ram's on-and-off lover who takes the two best friends under her wing, embark on a more untraditional education from the formal colonial schools which they were subjected to. Instead, the three devote themselves to the student movement in pursuit of political consciousness and liberation from the British. Though it is an informal education and one that exists under British university life, the result is not colonial subjectivity, but instead resistance. Ram emphasizes the transformative effect of their revolutionary learning: "We learnt, for the first time, the history of British imperialism and why we didn't want the British troops in the Suez Canal area... Gradually, we began to see ourselves as members of humanity in general and not just as Egyptians."²³ Here, Ram speaks with sincerity apart from his usual cynicism, showing how revolutionary education existed beyond colonial frameworks. Ram's experiences, as a protester at the Suez with Font and as a student learning not from the colonial systems embedded in his education but rather the diverse revolutionary

²¹ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 20.

²² Ngũgĩ, *Decolonising the Mind*, 28.

²³ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 52-53.

books he and Font devour, directly contrast Ngũgĩ's ideas that colonial schools produce total alienation and fragmentation. Ngũgĩ writes, "To control a people's culture is to control their tools of self-definition in relationship to others."²⁴ Applying this to Ram, his culture is controlled by the British. However, instead of just existing as passive subjects, Ram is critically aware of the Western forces which shape his world and thus influence his sense of humor as a way to define his own identity. The colonial school system failed in the sense that it allowed Ram to appropriate its language for his own thinking, in comparison to producing the fracturedness Ngũgĩ describes.

Although Ram possesses self-awareness when it comes to understanding the British influence, his encounter with the English soldier, Steve, in London reveals how colonial subjectivity is imposed upon him regardless of that awareness. At this point in the novel, Ram, Font, and Edna are physically in the colonizer's country itself, further representing how deeply intertwined they have become between East and West. When Steve speaks to them about his time fighting at Suez, he talks about Egyptians as though the three are not Egyptian themselves. Rather, they are positioned as passive observers who might be aligned with the British gaze. He addresses them as outsiders to their own culture: "'The natives'll fleece you if you're not careful,' and 'not safe after dark...you know what the wogs are like.'"²⁵ In doing so, Steve treats Egyptians as a racialized 'other,' reflecting Said's ideas of how Orientalism is constructed and reproduced. Yet, he fails to see that Ram and his companions are Egyptian themselves, treating them as

²⁴ Ngũgĩ, *Decolonising the Mind*, 16.

²⁵ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 85.

honored guests with tea and cake.²⁶ Ram feels the unsettling fragmentation of being caught between both worlds as he reflects, “With them I forgot I was Egyptian and they English and I a stranger in their midst.”²⁷ Because of the traumas and dislocations that colonial authority enforces, Ram experiences a fractured identity. He is both in and outside the colonizer’s world. In this case, when in London, Ram both engages with otherness and ironic inclusion. Though his self-awareness allows him to critically joke about the absurdity of Steve’s comments, he cannot fully escape from the alienation that comes with being defined by the dominant culture.

Said describes this sort of subjectivity in *Orientalism*, which is illustrated through his discussion of Gustave Flaubert, a French writer who visited the ‘Orient’ and wrote about his travels. When visiting Egypt, he encounters an Egyptian prostitute, who “never spoke of herself, she never represented her emotions, presence, or history. [Flaubert] spoke for and represented her.”²⁸ This portrayal became an influential model for how the West perceived Oriental subjects. Like Flaubert’s representation, Ram, Font, and Edna are spoken for by a British soldier. Their identity is defined through the colonial gaze. Yet, Ram resists this imposed subjectivity through his humor. When recalling this moment, in true Ram-fashion, he ironically comments that “Dirty Arabs and wogs were as much a menace to us as they had been to his beloved regiment.”²⁹ Not only does he mock the absurdity of the soldier’s prejudices, but also maintains a sense of agency, laughing at the very stereotypes used to categorize him. Unlike the Egyptian woman who

²⁶ Ibid.

²⁷ Ibid., 101.

²⁸ Said, *Orientalism*, 6.

²⁹ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 85.

Flaubert meets, Ram does have a voice, as he co-opts the English language to challenge the colonizer's authority.

Though Ram uses his cynical voice to critique the same colonial subjectivities that Said illustrates in *Orientalism*, Ghali's protagonist also internalizes and reproduces notions of Western supremacy and cultural hierarchy. Though he strongly identifies as an Egyptian and repeatedly claims how humor is central to the identity of the Egyptian, he is also estranged from the social and cultural realities of his homeland. This estrangement exemplifies Ngũgĩ's argument in *Decolonising the Mind*, where colonial domination did not just involve the "deliberate undervaluing" of the African (or other colonized) cultures but also the "conscious elevation" of European culture and language as the universal standard.³⁰ This can be understood in Said's explanation of Orientalism, which shows how the West is defined as the standard in relation to the way the East is constructed.³¹ Neither the Orient nor the Occident are facts of nature, but instead are "man-made."³² Ram is a product of this hierarchy as a student of British schools. Despite his anti-imperialist views, he participates in Orientalism through his imagination of European life, which he describes before he goes to London with Font and Edna:

"The world where students had rooms, and typists for girlfriends, and sang songs and drank beer in large mugs, shouted to us. A whole imaginary world. A mixture of all the cities in Europe; where pubs were confused with zinc bars and where Piccadilly led to the Champs-Élysées...I wanted to live. I wanted to have affairs

³⁰ Ngũgĩ, *Decolonising the Mind*, 16.

³¹ Said, *Orientalism*, 2.

³² *Ibid.*, 4.

with countesses and to fall in love with a barmaid and to be a gigolo and to be a political leader and to win at Monte Carlo and to be down-and-out in London and to be an artist and to be elegant and also to be in rags.”³³

Ram’s romanticization of the West reveals how his inner desires are shaped by Occidentalism. Though he continues to criticize and mock the British, he also actively engages in the systems that put the West above Egypt. Therefore, Ram embodies both Said and Ngũgĩ’s arguments as he represents a colonized subject aspiring to European norms.

However, it is also interesting to note that despite Ram’s internalization of Occidentalism, he also maintains a critical understanding of his European visions. He declares that Font and himself left “For dreamed-of Europe, for ‘civilization,’ for ‘freedom of speech,’ for ‘culture,’ for ‘life.’”³⁴ The quotation marks around the seemingly ‘European’ ideals highlight Ram’s sarcasm. He is using the language of the colonizer, yet mocks their superiority, despite his yearning for Europe. Here, Ram engages with the language and ideals of the colonizer—even going as so far as to fantasize about living (and eventually does live) within this mythologized European world—while also satirizing Western values and their “positional superiority,”³⁵ as Said puts it.

The dynamics between Ram and Edna is important in understanding and analyzing Ram’s relationship with his Egyptian identity and humor. After meeting Edna, Ram’s perception of his country completely changes. He and Font begin to study political books

³³ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 55.

³⁴ *Ibid.*, 60.

³⁵ Said, *Orientalism*, 7.

and become conscious of the world around them. Though Ram grew up in Cairo, he says “It was Edna who introduced me to Egyptian people. It is rare, in the milieu in which I was born, to know Egyptians.”³⁶ Through her guidance, Ram begins to develop his self-awareness and recognizes the ways in which colonialism has estranged Egyptians from their land and traditions. Edna’s immersion in the villages and communal life of the *fellaheen* expose him to a more authentic vision of Egypt, contrasting the Westernized world he grew up in.³⁷ Through this perspective, it can be understood that Edna’s influence on Ram and his growing awareness of his identity as an Egyptian allow him to develop his sarcastic voice. Without the awareness she instills, Ram would lack the critical perspective necessary to mock the colonial powers and navigate the contradictions of his position between East and West.

Later in the novel, during the present timeline, Ram furthers his position of humor as a criteria of national identity in a heated confrontation with Edna. He asserts directly, “I am real Egyptian. I have our humour. Even though my ‘Egyptian’ has been enfeebled by my stay in England and by the books I have read, I have the Egyptian character. You haven’t.”³⁸ As he insists that he is the true Egyptian, rather than the figure who he previously admits expanded his ideas about the Egyptian people, Ram falls short of recognizing that his sense of authenticity is exclusionary. Though Ram is confident that humor defines what makes one Egyptian, his perspective is limited by the narrowness of his own experiences and his failure to engage with Egypt’s diverse social and cultural

³⁶ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 53.

³⁷ *Ibid.*, 107.

³⁸ *Ibid.*, 185.

landscape. He mockingly tells Edna, “So you are an Israeli,”³⁹ highlighting how his humor, while a tool for resisting subjectivity, also enforces boundaries which mirror the hierarchies internalized through colonial education. Ram indeed represents how colonial influence complicates self-definition. His policing of the Egyptian identity can be compared to Said’s analysis of Flaubert and the question of who should speak for the colonial subject?⁴⁰ One of Edna’s major criticisms of Ram is that he is isolated from the real Egyptians beyond the country’s two metropolitan cities. His only relative who speaks Arabic is his uncle from Upper Egypt,⁴¹ who serves as a reminder of the language which Ram and the rest of his family are estranged from. This gap between Ram’s social class in Cairo versus the working class majority of Egyptians reflects Ngũgĩ’s contrasting ideas of “the culture of the peasantry and in the culture of the metropolitan bourgeoisie.”⁴² Although Ghali’s satirical voice proves that the colonial subject can resist against the dominant culture, he does not account for the limits of such resistance.

Caught between national, ideological, and cultural identities, Ram epitomizes the complexities and contradictions of postcolonial Egyptian society. In the end, he shockingly abandons his revolutionary ideals and gets engaged to Didi Nackla, the wealthy girl whom his arch-nemesis cousin Mounir had intended to marry.⁴³ Just as he used his mocking sense of humor with Edna, the one who got away, Ram repeats his offenses with Didi—though she is more immature to Ram’s wit, and agrees to marry him

³⁹ Ibid.

⁴⁰ Said, *Orientalism*, 6.

⁴¹ Ibid., 161.

⁴² Ngũgĩ, *Decolonising the Mind*, 21.

⁴³ Ghali, *Beer in the Snooker Club*, 210.

after he asks very unseriously: “‘But but but but,’ I mimicked. ‘If you love someone, you marry him.’”⁴⁴ When directed at women like Edna or Didi, Ram’s humor reveals more about his insecurities than his confidence. His mocking wit positions the women as immature or compliant, which seemingly allows him to maintain control and avoid emotional vulnerability. Unlike the satire he embodies against British authority, here his jokes show how his humor can reproduce some of the same inequalities of colonialism—in this case, it is gender inequality—that Ram is seemingly against.

Humor symbolizes the fracturedness of the colonial subject’s identity, where it is both used as a way for Ram to reclaim the colonizer’s language while also exposing limitations imposed by colonial education. In analyzing this fragmentation, Ram’s humor can also be seen as a coping mechanism—a way to navigate the traumas of alienation. The same wit that enables resistance cannot resolve the deeper fractures imposed by colonial powers. Through *Beer in the Snooker Club*, Ghali not only offers a literary exploration of humor, but also a historical account of Egypt as experienced through the subjectivity endured by colonial subjects in British schools, such as Ram and Font. The novel predates both Ngũgĩ’s *Decolonising the Mind* and Said’s *Orientalism*, but prefigures their critiques of British education and the tensions between language, power, and identity within the colonial school.

⁴⁴ Ibid., 208.

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